

## Chapter Six

### The Woman Across the Street

Nora fell into grief before she found the body.

It was not like Maya's grief, which had been held tightly behind the ribs. It was not like Adam's, careful and controlled, hidden beneath the shape of usefulness. It was not like Daniel's, exhausted and practical, folded between rent and hospital corridors and a child's pink coat.

This grief had no structure.

It was everywhere.

It filled the lungs before Nora understood whose lungs they were. It trembled through the hands before she knew she had hands. It made the world too bright, too sharp, too impossible to receive.

She was standing on the sidewalk across from Saint Orla's.

No.

The woman was standing.

Nora was only inside her.

The woman's breath came in short, broken pulls. Her chest hurt. Her right hand was pressed against it, fingers digging into the wool of a gray coat buttoned wrong. At her feet, apples rolled slowly toward the curb from a torn paper bag.

One apple bumped against the wheel of a parked bicycle and stopped.

Nora wanted to look back at the garden.

At Maya.

At herself.

But the woman's gaze remained fixed on the church doors.

The bells had stopped ringing, yet their echo seemed to remain inside her bones.

A man's voice crackled through the phone in the woman's left hand.

"Mrs. Rose? Are you still there?"

The name entered Nora like a label pinned to borrowed skin.

Anna Rose.

Fifty-two years old.

Hands rough from years of cleaning hotel rooms. Left knee aching when it rained. A gold wedding ring too loose now because she had lost weight without meaning to.

The knowledge came in fragments, not as biography, but as weight.

"Mrs. Rose?" the voice repeated. "I'm sorry. I know this is difficult."

Difficult.

The word moved through Anna with a strange, hollow violence.

Difficult was carrying groceries up three flights of stairs when the elevator broke.

Difficult was smiling at guests who left towels on the floor and coins by the sink as if kindness could be measured in leftovers.

Difficult was teaching herself to sleep on one side of the bed after her husband died.

This was not difficult.

This was a before and an after.

Anna's thumb moved at last.

She ended the call.

The phone screen went dark.

In the reflection, Nora saw Anna's face: skin drained pale, dark eyes wide with shock, hair pulled back badly, gray strands loose at the temples.

Not her face.

Another face.

Another life.

Nora tried to breathe through the panic, but Anna's grief owned the lungs.

A memory opened.

A boy at six years old, kneeling on a kitchen chair, elbows in flour.

"Mama, look. Snow."

Anna laughing as flour covered the counter, the floor, his eyelashes.

Another memory.

The same boy at thirteen, slamming a bedroom door.

"You don't understand anything."

Anna standing outside the door with a plate of cut mango, pretending his anger did not hurt because adolescence was supposed to be a kind of weather.

Another.

The boy older now. Seventeen. Taller than her. A university acceptance letter shaking in his hands.

"Mama," he whispered. "I got in."

Anna putting both hands over her mouth because joy, too, could make the body forget how to stand.

Then the memory changed.

Hospital light.

A white curtain.

A young man in a bed.

Not asleep.

Too still.

A doctor saying words Anna could not keep in order.

Accident.

Internal bleeding.

We did everything.

We are so sorry.

The memory collapsed.

Nora returned to the sidewalk inside Anna's body just as Anna bent forward with a sound that did not seem human enough to belong to speech.

The grief tore through her.

Nora had thought she understood pain by now.

She did not.

This was a mother's grief.

It had no bottom.

For one terrifying second, Nora forgot herself completely. She was not Nora Reyes, engaged to Adam Cruz, chosen sister to Maya Santos. She was Anna Rose, mother of Leo, widow of James, woman standing outside a church because some instinct had led her toward God before the hospital called and removed the last piece of her future.

Leo.

The name broke through her.

Leo.

Leo.

Leo.

Anna's knees gave way.

She would have fallen if someone had not caught her.

Hands closed around her arms.

“Ma’am? Are you okay?”

A young man's voice.

Anna tried to pull away, but the body had no strength. Her phone slipped from her fingers and hit the pavement. Someone else stepped closer. A woman. Concerned. Too loud.

“Should we call an ambulance?”

“No,” Anna said.

It came out as a whisper.

The young man bent slightly, trying to see her face. “Do you have someone we can call?”

Someone.

The word echoed.

Anna had many people who would come. A neighbor. Her sister in another city. A cousin who had always said, “Call me if you need anything,” with the easy kindness of people who did not expect the anything to arrive.

But the only person she wanted was gone.

The thought was too large for the body.

Nora felt herself recoil inside Anna, horrified by the intimacy of this pain. She had no right to be here. No right to stand inside the most devastating minute of this woman's life. No right to know the name Leo, the flour on his eyelashes, the mango plate outside the bedroom door.

Let me out, Nora thought.

Please.

But the world held.

Anna's eyes lifted.

Across the street, inside the church garden, Maya stood near the bench.

Nora saw her through Anna's eyes.

Maya was gripping the iron gate, scanning the street with wild panic. Her face was pale. Her mouth moved around Nora's name, though the sound did not reach across the road.

Then Maya saw Anna.

No.

Maya saw Nora inside Anna.

Not truly. Not visibly.

But she seemed to understand enough to be afraid.

She stepped toward the street.

A car horn blared.

Maya jumped back.

Anna's body flinched at the sound, and the world smeared sideways.

Another memory opened.

Leo at eight, running ahead at a crosswalk.

Anna shouting, "Wait!"

His small hand slipping from hers.

A bus rushing past.

Nothing happened then. He stopped in time. He turned back, laughing, startled by her fear.

“Mama, I’m okay!”

But memory was cruel. It took an old almost-loss and placed it beside the real one until Anna could not tell whether her heart had been breaking for years in preparation.

The young man beside her said, “Let’s sit down.”

Anna allowed herself to be guided to the low stone wall outside the church. Her body obeyed because bodies were strange that way. They continued after the impossible. They sat. They breathed. They accepted water from strangers.

Someone placed her grocery bag beside her, repaired badly, apples bruised inside.

A woman in a blue scarf crouched in front of her.

“Can you tell us your name?”

Anna looked at her.

Name.

What use was a name when the person who called you Mama was gone?

“Anna,” she said.

“Anna, I’m going to stay with you, okay?”

Kindness.

Nora felt it enter Anna and fail to reach the center.

The woman in the blue scarf kept speaking gently. The young man picked up Anna’s phone and asked if there was someone in it he could call. Anna did not answer.

Across the street, Maya had disappeared from the gate.

Panic shot through Nora.

Where did she go?

The thought was Nora's, clean and separate.

For one instant, she became aware of herself again, trapped beneath Anna's grief like someone buried under snow.

Maya.

Adam.

Her own body sitting or lying or collapsed somewhere in the garden.

What was happening to it while she was gone?

Could it breathe without her?

Could it die?

The fear pulled at the edges of the jump.

The church blurred.

Anna's hands clenched around nothing.

The pressure behind Nora's eyes shifted, and for a second she thought she was returning.

Then a new sound anchored her.

A ringtone.

Anna's phone.

The young man held it up. "Someone named Isabel is calling."

Anna's sister.

The knowledge came with the image of a woman who laughed too loudly and always wore red lipstick, even to the laundromat.

Anna's mouth opened.

No sound.



The phone rang again.

The young man looked uncertain. “Do you want me to answer?”

Anna nodded once.

He accepted the call and held it near her ear.

“Anna?” a woman’s voice said. “Anna, what happened? The hospital called me too. Tell me it’s not true.”

Anna made a sound.

Not a word.

Her sister began crying on the other end.

That sound did what the doctor’s voice had not.

It made the loss communal.

Real.

Witnessed.

Anna folded forward, phone pressed to her ear, and the sob finally came.

It tore through both women: Anna, who had lost her son, and Nora, who had entered the room of that loss without permission and now could not find the door out.

The street warped.

The church wall stretched upward.

The woman in the blue scarf became a blur of color.

Nora felt the jump loosening.

Not because Anna’s grief had ended.

Because Nora could not hold it.

She was being pushed out by the sheer force of a life that did not belong to her.

The last thing she felt was Anna's hand moving to her chest, searching for the small cross beneath her coat.

The last thing she heard was Isabel saying, "I'm coming. I'm coming. Don't move."

Then the world split.

Nora returned with a scream in her throat.

This time she was not alone.

She was lying on the grass in the old church garden with Maya kneeling over her, both hands pressed to Nora's shoulders.

"Nora!"

Nora gasped.

Air entered her lungs too fast.

Her own lungs.

Her own body.

The garden spun above her, branches slicing the gray sky into trembling pieces.

"Nora, look at me."

Maya's face hovered over her.

Terrified.

"Nora, please. Look at me."

Nora tried.

For a second, Maya's face became Anna's. Then Anna's became Maya's. Then both dissolved into wet light.

"Leo," Nora whispered.

Maya froze. "What?"

Nora turned onto her side and retched into the grass.

Nothing came up.

Her body shook violently.

Maya held her hair back with one hand and kept the other on Nora's back.

"I'm here," Maya said. "I'm here."

But Nora could still hear Isabel crying.

She could still feel the phone against Anna's ear.

She could still see flour on a boy's eyelashes.

When the shaking finally softened, Maya helped her sit upright against the bench. Nora's coat was damp from the grass. Her palms were dirty. Her head throbbed with each heartbeat.

"How long?" Nora asked.

Maya wiped tears from her own face with the back of her hand. "Maybe two minutes. Maybe less. I don't know."

Two minutes.

A lifetime of a stranger's grief in two minutes.

Nora looked toward the gate.

Across the street, Anna Rose sat on the stone wall, surrounded by strangers. A young man stood beside her holding her phone. A woman in a blue scarf knelt in front of her. Apples lay scattered near the curb like small, useless offerings.

"She lost her son," Nora said.

Maya stared at her.

"Who?"

"The woman. Anna. Her son, Leo. The hospital called. There was an accident."

Maya slowly turned toward the street.

The woman's grief was visible even from across the road. Some kinds of pain altered the air around a person.

Maya's grip tightened around Nora's wrist.

"You were in her?"

Nora nodded.

Maya went very still.

The question neither of them wanted to ask sat between them.

If Nora had been inside a stranger across the street, then this was not only about Maya. Not only about Adam. Not only about secrets between people who loved her.

It was bigger.

Wilder.

Crueler.

Maya stood suddenly.

Nora grabbed her sleeve. "Where are you going?"

"To help her."

The answer came so quickly that Nora almost did not understand it.

"No." Panic rose. "Maya, don't."

Maya looked down at her. "Nora, that woman just lost her son."

"You don't know that."

Maya's face softened with something like horror. "You just told me."

"I know, but you can't go over there because of something I saw inside her. You can't know that. You shouldn't know that."

Maya stared at her.

Then she crouched again, slowly.

“Nora,” she said, “there are people already helping her. I won’t say anything I shouldn’t. But I can pick up her groceries. I can stand nearby. I can be useful without invading.”

Useful without invading.

The words struck too close.

Nora released her sleeve.

Maya crossed the street carefully this time, waiting for the light, arms wrapped around herself against the cold.

Nora stayed in the garden, watching.

She felt hollowed out.

Maya approached the scene gently. She did not rush in. She did not announce knowledge. She knelt near the fallen apples and gathered them back into the torn bag. One had split on the pavement. Maya set it aside. She spoke briefly to the woman in the blue scarf, then stood a few feet away, present but not demanding entry.

Nora watched and felt something inside her rearrange painfully.

This was what she had failed to do.

Witness without taking ownership.

Help without making the pain hers.

Stay near without forcing the door.

Her phone began ringing in her pocket.

Adam.

Nora answered with shaking hands.

“Nora?” His voice was already frightened. “Maya texted me. She said something happened.”

Nora closed her eyes.

“Yes.”

“Are you hurt?”

“No.”

A pause.

“Was it another jump?”

“Yes.”

“Who?”

“A woman outside the church.”

Adam was silent long enough for Nora to hear traffic on his end.

Then he said, “I’m coming.”

This time, Nora did not say no.

“Okay,” she whispered.

Adam arrived fifteen minutes later, breathless, hair windblown, coat unbuttoned as if he had dressed while moving. He entered the garden and stopped when he saw Nora on the bench.

The look on his face nearly broke her.

Not suspicion.

Not fear of her.

Fear for her.

He crossed the path quickly, then slowed before touching her.

“Can I?” he asked.

Nora nodded.

He sat beside her and took her hand carefully, as if she might be injured in ways he could not see.

Maya returned a few minutes later.

“The woman’s sister is coming,” she said softly. “Someone is staying with her.”

She sat on Nora’s other side.

For a while, the three of them said nothing.

They sat in the old church garden as the afternoon thinned toward evening, Nora between the two people she had nearly pushed away with fear.

No one knew what to do.

That was strangely comforting.

Adam was the first to speak.

“We need rules.”

Maya let out a weak laugh. “You and rules.”

“I’m serious.”

“I know. That’s why it’s funny.”

Nora looked at him. “What kind of rules?”

Adam’s thumb moved carefully across her knuckles. “For what happens after a jump. For safety. For information. For consent, if that word can even apply here.”

Consent.

Nora flinched.

Adam noticed. “I’m not blaming you.”

“You should.”

“No,” Maya said.

Nora turned to her.

Maya’s face was tired but firm. “You didn’t choose to enter that woman. But what we do with what you learn afterward—that part is a choice.”

The sentence settled over them.

Adam nodded slowly. “Exactly.”

Nora looked between them, overwhelmed by the fact that they were sitting beside her, trying to build a structure around the impossible instead of running from it.

“I don’t know how to control it,” she said.

“Then we don’t start with control,” Adam said. “We start with care.”

Maya leaned back against the bench. “Rule one: after a jump, Nora sits down before doing anything dramatic.”

Despite everything, Nora almost smiled.

Adam nodded. “Rule two: she tells us if she feels one coming.”

“If I can.”

“If you can,” he agreed.

Maya added, “Rule three: we don’t use strangers’ private pain unless someone is in immediate danger.”

Nora looked toward the street.

Anna was gone now. Only one bruised apple remained near the curb.

Immediate danger.

Private pain.

Borrowed lives.

The language felt inadequate, but it was all they had.

“And rule four,” Adam said quietly, “Nora does not disappear afterward.”

Nora looked down at their joined hands.

That rule was not about the jumps.



Not only.

It was about last night. The unanswered calls. The silence she had built like a wall and then called protection.

“I’ll try,” she said.

Maya’s shoulder touched hers.

“Trying counts,” Maya said. “But hiding doesn’t.”

Nora nodded.

The church bells rang again at the hour.

This time, the sound did not pull her away.

Still, all three of them went quiet until the final bell faded.

Only then did Nora breathe.

Adam heard it.

Maya did too.

Neither of them commented.

The sky darkened slowly over Saint Orla’s. Lights appeared in the windows of nearby apartments. Somewhere, a child laughed. Somewhere else, someone was receiving the worst news of their life.

The world was full of doors.

Nora could feel them now.

Not clearly.

Not constantly.

But in flashes.

Emotional pressure behind ordinary faces. A man passing the gate with anger burning under his calm expression. A woman on a bicycle carrying joy so bright it almost hurt to look at her. A

teenager near the bus stop with loneliness wrapped around him like a second coat.

Other people's weather.

That was how it felt.

Storms moving behind skin.

Nora closed her eyes.

For the first time, she understood that the jumps were not only showing her secrets.

They were showing her that every person was a country of hidden weather, and she had been thrown across borders without a map.

When she opened her eyes, Maya and Adam were both watching her.

Afraid.

Loving.

Waiting.

Nora held Adam's hand on one side and let Maya's shoulder press against hers on the other.

"I don't want to become someone who only sees pain," she said.

Maya's voice was soft. "Then we'll remind you there are other things."

Adam squeezed her hand. "And you'll remind us what you need."

Nora looked toward the street where Anna had been.

The bruised apple still lay by the curb, split open, pale flesh exposed to the evening air.

A small ruined thing.

A thing that had fallen from someone else's life and remained behind.

Nora understood it too well.

She leaned into Maya.

Not because everything was repaired.

Not because she was safe.

But because, for now, she was still here.

Still Nora.

Still held.

And for one fragile hour, no one let go.

DaintyHub